

DEFINITIVE EARLY-STAGE VENTURE INTELLIGENCE • SEED TO SERIES C

SEED_ROUND: THE MASTER EARLY-STAGE CAPITAL COMPENDIUM

Comprehensive Audit of Seed, Series A, Series B, and Series C Financings Across YC & AI Powerhouses

CONFIDENTIAL EXECUTIVE BRIEFING • PREPARED FOR LEADERSHIP • SEC FORM D & VENTURE DISCLOSURES

EARLY-STAGE FINANCING MECHANICS & GOVERNANCE ARCHITECTURE:

- **Seed Stage (SAFE / Convertible Debt):** Characterized by post-money valuation caps (\$5M-\$20M) standardized on Carolyn Levy's YC SAFE instrument. Handled via Cooley GO, Gunderson Launch, or WSGR.
- **Series A (The Institutional Price Discovery):** The initial creation of Series A Preferred Stock (\$5M-\$25M raised; 15-25% dilution). Lead partner takes Board of Directors seat.
- **Series B & C (Scale & Expansion Rounds):** Multi-firm syndicates (\$25M-\$250M raised) with protective covenants, anti-dilution rights, and secondary founder liquidity.

1. THE EARLY-STAGE ROUND-BY-ROUND LIFECYCLE (SEED • SERIES A • SERIES B • SERIES C)

COMPANY & TIER	CAPITAL RAISED & VALUATION	LEAD VC FIRM & LEAD PARTNERS	LAW FIRM(S) & STRUCTURING PARTNERS	DEAL TERMS, BOARD SEATS & MILESTONES
OpenAI Seed (2015)	\$130M Initial Cash (\$1.0B Non-Profit Pledge)	Sam Altman, Elon Musk, Reid Hoffman, Peter Thiel, Jessica Livingston	Wilson Sonsini (WSGR) & Cooley LLP	Formed as non-profit 501(c)(3) AI research lab with zero equity ownership; broad public benefit mandate.
OpenAI Series A / Capped (2019)	\$1.05 Billion (\$1.0B Microsoft + \$50M Khosla)	Khosla Ventures (Vinod Khosla) & Microsoft (Satya Nadella, Kevin Scott)	Wilson Sonsini (WSGR), Cooley LLP, Simpson Thacher	Creation of OpenAI Global LLC capped-profit structure (100x profit cap); exclusive Azure cloud computing exclusivity.
OpenAI Series B (2021)	\$250 Million (\$14.0B Post-Money Val)	Microsoft, Bedrock Capital, Sequoia Capital, a16z, Founders Fund, Tiger Global	Cooley LLP (Rachel Proffitt), Paul, Weiss	Commercialization of GPT-3 API; enterprise SaaS pilots with Morgan Stanley, Stripe, and Duolingo.
OpenAI Series C (2023)	\$10.3 Billion (\$29.0B Post-Money Val)	Microsoft (\$10B Lead), Thrive Capital (Josh Kushner), Founders Fund, Sequoia	Paul, Weiss (Robert Schumer), Cooley LLP, Wachtell Lipton	ChatGPT breakout commercial expansion; 75% Microsoft profit share until investment recoupment; Azure deployment.
Anthropic Series A (May 2021)	\$124 Million (\$250M Valuation)	Jaan Tallinn (Skype Co-Founder), Dustin Moskovitz, Eric Schmidt, James McClave	Wilson Sonsini (WSGR) (Steven Bochner)	Spinoff from OpenAI by Dario and Daniela Amodei; established as a Delaware Public Benefit Corporation (PBC) with Long-Term Benefit Trust.
Anthropic Series B (Apr 2022)	\$580 Million (\$850M Valuation)	Sam Bankman-Fried / FTX (later sold off), Jim McClave, Nishad Singh	Wilson Sonsini (WSGR)	Massive compute financing for Constitutional AI R&D; later repurchased and re-syndicated to global sovereign funds post-FTX bankruptcy.
Anthropic Series C (May 2023)	\$450 Million (\$4.1B Valuation)	Spark Capital (Yasmin Razavi - Board Observer), Google, Salesforce Ventures, Sound Ventures	Wilson Sonsini (WSGR) (Mark Baudler)	Launch of Claude 2; commercial rollout across enterprise clients (Zoom, Slack, Bridgewater); Google Cloud compute partnership.
DoorDash Seed (2013 - YC S13)	\$2.4 Million (\$8.0M Valuation)	CRV (Charles River Ventures) (Saar Gur), SV Angel, Paul Buchheit, Pejman Mar	Wilson Sonsini (WSGR) (Tony Jeffries)	YC Post-Money SAFE conversion; initial rollout across Palo Alto / Stanford delivery radius; Saar Gur joined Board.
DoorDash Series A (May 2014)	\$17.3 Million (\$60M Valuation)	Sequoia Capital (Alfred Lin - joined Board), CRV, Khosla Ventures	Wilson Sonsini (WSGR) (Tony Jeffries)	Creation of Series A Preferred Stock; national expansion across Silicon Valley, Los Angeles, and Boston; dispatch logistics algorithms.

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DoorDash Series B (Mar 2015)	\$40.0 Million (\$200M Valuation)	Kleiner Perkins (John Doerr) , Sequoia Capital, CRV, Khosla Ventures	Wilson Sonsini (WSGR)	Expansion into 18 major metropolitan markets; launch of corporate ordering and merchant analytics dashboards.
DoorDash Series C (Mar 2016)	\$127.0 Million (\$600M Valuation)	Sequoia Capital (Alfred Lin) , Kleiner Perkins, YC Continuity Fund (Ali Rowghani)	Wilson Sonsini (WSGR) (Steven Bochner, Tony Jeffries)	Down-market pricing defense; expansion of DashPass subscription architecture; multi-city market share capture from Grubhub.
Airbnb Seed (2009 - YC W09)	\$600,000 (\$2.4M Valuation)	Sequoia Capital (Greg McAdoo, Roelof Botha) , Youniversity (Keith Rabois)	Fenwick & West LLP (Mark Stevens)	YC Seed investment after famous "Obama O's" cereal box survival; incorporation and early trademark registration.
Airbnb Series A (Nov 2010)	\$7.2 Million (\$65M Valuation)	Greylock Partners (Reid Hoffman - joined Board) , Sequoia Capital (Greg McAdoo)	Fenwick & West LLP (Mark Stevens)	Series A Preferred stock; international room nights scaling; professional photography program for hosts.
Airbnb Series B (Jul 2011)	\$112.0 Million (\$1.3B Unicorn Valuation)	Andreessen Horowitz (Jeff Jordan - joined Board) , DST Global, General Catalyst	Fenwick & West LLP & Cooley LLP	Cross-border European expansion; acquisition of German clone Accoleo; reached 1M nights booked.
Airbnb Series C (Oct 2012)	\$200.0 Million (\$2.5B Valuation)	Founders Fund (Peter Thiel, Brian Singerman) , Sequoia, a16z, Greylock	Fenwick & West LLP & Simpson Thacher	\$1M Host Guarantee insurance program; global localized payment processing across 30+ currencies.
Stripe Seed (2010 - YC S09)	\$2.0 Million (\$10M Valuation)	Peter Thiel, Elon Musk, Sequoia Capital (Michael Moritz) , SV Angel (Ron Conway)	Fenwick & West LLP (Mark Stevens, Gordon Davidson)	7 lines of JavaScript payment API; Patrick and John Collison seed syndicate backed by PayPal mafia co-founders.
Stripe Series A (Feb 2012)	\$18.0 Million (\$100M Valuation)	Sequoia Capital (Michael Moritz - joined Board) , General Catalyst, Peter Thiel, Elad Gil	Fenwick & West LLP	Series A Preferred stock; banking sponsor agreements with Wells Fargo; launch of developer dashboard and webhooks.
Stripe Series B (Jan 2014)	\$80.0 Million (\$1.75B Unicorn Valuation)	Founders Fund (Peter Thiel - joined Board) , Sequoia Capital, Allen & Company	Fenwick & West LLP & WSGR	Global expansion into Europe and Canada; launch of Stripe Connect for marketplaces (Shopify, Lyft, Kickstarter).
Stripe Series C (Dec 2014)	\$70.0 Million (\$3.5B Valuation)	Thrive Capital (Josh Kushner - joined Board) , Founders Fund, Sequoia, General Catalyst	Fenwick & West LLP & WSGR	Launch of Stripe Relay (mobile checkout) and Stripe Atlas (Delaware company formation for global founders).
Scale AI Seed (2016 - YC S16)	\$4.5 Million (\$18M Valuation)	Accel (Dan Levine) , SV Angel, Y Combinator	Cooley LLP (Rachel Proffitt)	Alexandr Wang (age 19) and Lucy Guo founding round; initial data labeling API for autonomous vehicle perception (LiDAR/Camera).
Scale AI Series A (Jul 2017)	\$18.0 Million (\$70M Valuation)	Index Ventures (Mike Volpi - joined Board) , Accel	Cooley LLP	Series A Preferred stock; expansion into sensor fusion labeling; landing major autonomous vehicle contracts (Cruise, Waymo, Lyft).
Scale AI Series B (Aug 2018)	\$100.0 Million (\$350M Valuation)	Founders Fund (Mike Vernal - joined Board) , Index Ventures, Accel	Cooley LLP	Launch of Scale 3D and Scale Text; expansion into federal defense and aerospace computer vision.

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Scale AI Series C (Aug 2019)	\$100.0 Million (\$1.04B Unicorn Valuation)	Founders Fund (Peter Thiel) , Coatue Management, Index Ventures, Accel	Cooley LLP (Rachel Proffitt)	Unicorn status achieved at age 22; launch of RLHF (reinforcement learning from human feedback) data pipelines for LLMs.
Perplexity AI Seed (Sep 2022)	\$3.1 Million (\$12M Valuation)	Elad Gil, Nat Friedman , Pieter Abbeel, Yann LeCun, Andrej Karpathy, Ashish Vaswani	Cooley LLP	Aravind Srinivas founding round; initial text-to-SQL and conversational web indexing prototypes.
Perplexity AI Series A (Mar 2023)	\$25.6 Million (\$150M Valuation)	New Enterprise Associates (NEA) (Ann Bordetsky - Board Seat), Databricks Ventures, Elad Gil, Nat Friedman	Cooley LLP	Launch of Perplexity Pro search engine; real-time web citation architecture; reached 2M monthly active users.
Perplexity AI Series B (Jan 2024)	\$73.6 Million (\$520M Valuation)	IVP (Cobi Hoover) , Jeff Bezos (Bezos Expeditions), Nvidia, Bessemer Venture Partners	Cooley LLP (Rachel Proffitt)	Enterprise Pro search launch; Rabbit R1 integration; search volume grew to 100M monthly queries.
Perplexity AI Series C (Apr 2024)	\$62.7 Million (\$1.04B Unicorn Valuation)	Daniel Gross, Stanley Druckenmiller , Garry Tan, IVP, NEA	Cooley LLP	Unicorn status reached; multi-model selector (Claude 3.5, GPT-4o, Sonar); official publisher revenue share syndicate.
Mistral AI Seed (Jun 2023)	€105 Million (\$113M) (€240M Valuation)	Lightspeed Venture Partners (Antoine Moyroud) , Xavier Niel, Eric Schmidt, Bpifrance	Cooley LLP (Peter Werner) & Clifford Chance	Largest seed round in European history (4 weeks post-incorporation by former DeepMind/Meta AI researchers Arthur Mensch, Timothée Lacroix).
Mistral AI Series A (Dec 2023)	€385 Million (\$415M) (€2.0B Valuation)	Andreessen Horowitz (a16z) , Lightspeed, Salesforce, BNP Paribas, General Catalyst	Cooley LLP & Clifford Chance	Release of Mixtral 8x7B (Sparse Mixture-of-Experts architecture); enterprise partnership with Microsoft Azure.
Mistral AI Series B (Jun 2024)	€600 Million (\$640M) (€5.8B Valuation)	General Catalyst (Jeannette zu Fürstenberg) , Lightspeed, a16z, Nvidia, Bpifrance, Cisco	Cooley LLP & Clifford Chance	Release of Mistral Large 2 and Codestral; sovereign AI computing contracts with European governments and global enterprises.